

Week 1: Introduction to History

JSS1 Nigerian History — First Term Lesson Note (Deep-Dive Edition)

Introduction

Before studying the events of Nigeria's past, we must first understand what history is, why it matters, and how historians know about events that happened long before anyone alive today was born.

Meaning of History

History is the systematic study of past events, particularly those involving human societies. It examines what happened, when it happened, why it happened, and how it shaped the present. Nigerian History specifically focuses on the peoples, events, and developments that have shaped the territory now known as Nigeria.

Importance of History

- Helps us understand our origins and identity as a people
- Teaches lessons from the successes and mistakes of the past
- Builds a sense of national and cultural pride
- Helps explain why present-day institutions, borders, and customs exist as they do
- Preserves the achievements and contributions of earlier generations for the future

Sources of Nigerian History

Source	Description
Oral tradition	Stories, songs, proverbs, and accounts passed down by word of mouth from generation to generation
Written records	Documents such as journals, letters, government records, and books written by explorers, missionaries, and administrators
Archaeology	The scientific study of past societies through excavation of buried remains, settlements, and tools
Artifacts	Physical objects made or used by people in the past, such as pottery, bronzes, and weapons
Traditions and customs	Ongoing cultural practices, festivals, and institutions that carry knowledge of the past into the present

Real-Life Application

When elders in a community narrate how their town was founded, they are acting as living sources of oral history. Similarly, when archaeologists dig up ancient pottery or tools, they are using artifacts to reconstruct how people lived centuries ago, even without written records.

Vocabulary

Word	Meaning
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Oral tradition	Historical information passed down by speech across generations
Archaeology	The study of human history through excavation of sites and objects
Artifact	An object made or used by humans in the past, of historical interest

Evaluation Questions

- 1 Define history in your own words.
- 2 State three reasons why the study of history is important.
- 3 List the five main sources of Nigerian history discussed this week.
- 4 Explain the difference between oral tradition and written records as sources of history.
- 5 What is archaeology, and how does it help historians?
- 6 Give an example of an artifact and explain what it might tell us about the past.
- 7 Why might oral tradition sometimes change over time as it passes between generations?
- 8 How do festivals and customs serve as sources of history?
- 9 Give a real-life example of oral tradition from your own family or community.
- 10 In your own words, explain why history matters for understanding present-day Nigeria.